

Safe-Seat Washington

Two questions, measured separately: was the general election close, and did it offer a choice between the parties? (Observed, 2016–2024)

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AI-assisted drafting and analysis review. All figures are reproducible from public-record data and from the open-source scripts cited below, including `scripts/diag_seat_competition.py`, which builds the seat universe from certified statewide returns and fails loudly if any cycle does not reconcile to the statutory chamber size. The paper source, code, and data-acquisition recipe are public at <https://github.com/skirby359/who-decides>. Contact: kirby@tikorconsulting.com.

Companion to "[Who Decides Washington State?](#)" and the [electoral-health white paper](#) (Finding 2). Where the lead paper showed who turns out, this one asks what their ballot actually offered. **DRAFT — pending the independent-verification gate in [publication-checklist.md](#).**

Revision note (2026-07-27). This paper was substantially rebuilt after an adversarial review. Three defects were confirmed and corrected: the seat universe was incomplete for 2016 and 2018 (King County was absent from the statewide precinct files, costing 24 House seats per year); the "same-party" category was misclassified (the rule captured any race lacking a D-vs-R pairing, including D-vs-independent); and two distinct questions — whether a race was close, and whether it offered a partisan choice — were collapsed into one number. Headline figures have changed and Appendix G records the before/after. The claim that seats were "decided before November" has been withdrawn as unsupported by this design.

Abstract

Claims that most legislative seats are "safe" usually rest on a projected margin, which invites the rebuttal that the model is wrong. This paper discards the projection and counts observed general-election results for every partisan legislative and congressional seat on Washington's ballot from 2016 through 2024, then repeats the count in three comparison states. It measures two things separately, because they are different questions. **Candidate competition** asks whether the race was close, using the margin between the top two candidates regardless of party. **Partisan availability** asks whether the ballot offered both a Democrat and a Republican. Washington's top-two primary makes the distinction unavoidable: a general election can be a genuine contest between two Democrats, and it can also present a single unopposed candidate. In 2024, 111 of 133 seats (83.5%) were not close — decided by ten points or more, or uncontested — and 47 (35.3%) offered no Democratic-versus-Republican option. The two overlap but are not the same: of fifteen same-party generals, fourteen were also lopsided, but one was decided by six points. Across five cycles the not-close share runs 79–88% and the no-major-choice share 27–49%. The pattern is not confined to Washington: in the lower chambers of three comparison states, 89–94% of seats were not close. Safe seats are bipartisan, splitting 68 Democratic to 43 Republican in Washington in 2024. The results are insensitive to the competitiveness threshold, holding between 74% and 98% across cuts from 15 points to 5. The paper counts contests and margins; it does not establish when the binding choice occurred, and makes no claim about which party benefits.

Keywords: electoral competition; safe seats; uncontested elections; top-two primary; state legislatures; primary elections; Washington; New York; Texas; Idaho.

The question, and why "observed" matters

The standard "most seats are safe" claim usually rests on a *projection* — a model's predicted margin. That invites the obvious rebuttal: *your model could be wrong*. So this paper throws the projection out and counts the **actual** general-election result of every partisan legislative and congressional seat on Washington's ballot, 2016–2024. The unit is the **seat** — each State Representative position, each State Senator race up that cycle, each U.S. House race — the thing a voter actually marks.

Washington's **top-two primary** forces a distinction that most safe-seat work can elide. Because the two highest primary finishers advance regardless of party, a general election can be:

- a **single candidate**, with no opponent at all;
- **two candidates of the same party**, offering a real choice between people but none between parties;
- a **Democrat against a Republican**, the conventional case;

- a major-party candidate against a minor-party or independent one.

A 51–49 general between two Democrats is a contest. It is also a ballot with no cross-party option. Collapsing those facts into a single "non-competitive" number answers neither question well, so this paper reports two dimensions throughout:

dimension	question	measure
Candidate competition	Was it close?	margin between the top two candidates, any party
Partisan availability	Was there a D-vs-R choice?	which parties appeared on the ballot

The seat universe

Because an earlier version of this analysis under-counted, the universe is now built from the **certified statewide summary returns** and asserted against the statutory chamber size before anything is computed. Washington elects all 98 House positions and 10 U.S. House members every even year; the Senate is staggered.

year	House (want 98)	Senate	U.S. House (want 10)	total
2016	98	26	10	134
2018	98	25	10	133
2020	98	26	10	134
2022	98	25	10	133
2024	98	25	10	133

`scripts/diag_seat_competition.py` exits non-zero if any cycle fails this reconciliation. The prior approach derived races from the precinct-results table, where a race absent from the data simply disappeared rather than being detected as missing; Appendix G documents what that cost.

Dimension 1 — was the race close?

Margin between the top two candidates, regardless of party. "Not close" means a single candidate, or a margin of ten points or more.

year	seats	single candidate	Tossup <5	Lean 5–10	Likely 10–20	Solid 20+	not close
2016	134	27	8	8	32	59	88.1%
2018	133	15	19	9	24	66	78.9%
2020	134	14	11	11	28	70	83.6%
2022	133	24	10	8	31	60	86.5%
2024	133	23	10	12	23	65	83.5%

- **Defensible claim.** In a typical Washington cycle **roughly five in six legislative and congressional seats are not close**. In 2024, of 133 partisan seats only **22 (16.5%) were decided by under ten points**. The share runs 79–88% across a decade, with **2018 the least foreclosed year** — the blue-wave cycle, when 19 seats landed inside five points, more than double any other year in the series.
- **Safe seats are bipartisan.** Among 2024's not-close seats, **68 were won by Democrats and 43 by Republicans** — the expected product of a geographically sorted electorate. (Winner party is taken from the leading candidate, not inferred from aggregate party vote totals; Appendix G explains why that distinction mattered.)

Dimension 2 — did the ballot offer a partisan choice?

year	seats	D-v-R	D-v-D	R-v-R	D-v-other	R-v-other	single	no D-v-R
2016	134	69	4	5	15	14	27	48.5%
2018	133	97	6	0	14	1	15	27.1%
2020	134	97	8	1	9	5	14	27.6%
2022	133	86	10	6	2	5	24	35.3%
2024	133	86	8	7	6	3	23	35.3%

- Defensible claim.** In 2024, **47 of 133 Washington races — more than a third of the partisan ballot — offered no Democratic-versus-Republican option:** 23 had a single candidate, 15 pitted two candidates of the same party against each other, and 9 set a major-party candidate against a minor-party or independent one. This count is **threshold-free**: no margin cutoff enters it.
- The single-candidate count is the hardest number in the paper.** Twenty-three seats in 2024 presented voters with exactly one name. That is not a judgment about competitiveness; it is a headcount.
- 2016 is the outlier at 48.5%, and partly for a definitional reason — six different Independent-flavoured party-preference strings appeared that year. See the sensitivity test below.

The two dimensions are not the same question

Cross-tabulating them for 2024 shows where they agree and where they part:

	single	Tossup <5	Lean 5–10	Likely 10–20	Solid 20+
D-v-R	0	10	11	20	45
D-v-D	0	0	0	1	7
R-v-R	0	0	1	2	4
D-v-other	0	0	0	0	6
R-v-other	0	0	0	0	3
single candidate	23	0	0	0	0

Most same-party generals are also lopsided — 14 of 15 in 2024 exceeded ten points, and 11 exceeded twenty. But **one was a genuine contest**: Washington's 4th Congressional District, an R-vs-R general decided by **6.0 points** (Dan Newhouse). Treating that race as "non-competitive" because it lacked a Democrat would be wrong. It is a competitive election without a partisan choice, and the two-dimension design is what makes it visible.

Sensitivity: how party preference is read

Washington's top-two system has no nominees, only stated preferences. The published figures count only "Prefers Democratic/Democrat Party" and "Prefers Republican/GOP Party" as major; "Independent Dem.", "Ind. Republican", "Culture Republican" and "MAGA Republican" are counted as other. Folding those into the major parties moves the no-D-v-R share by:

year	strict (published)	loose	delta
2016	48.5%	45.5%	3.0
2018	27.1%	25.6%	1.5
2020	27.6%	25.4%	2.2
2022	35.3%	35.3%	0.0
2024	35.3%	34.6%	0.8

The rule matters in 2016 and is close to immaterial elsewhere.

The four-state comparison

The same count against each state's **lower chamber** — the one body fully up every cycle everywhere, so the comparison is like-for-like. Completeness is reported explicitly rather than assumed.

state (chamber)	loaded / expected	not close	no D-v-R
WA House 2024	98 / 98	87.8%	39.8% (39)
NY Assembly 2022	149 / 150	88.6%	32.2% (48)
TX House 2024	96 / 150 + 54 backfilled	94.0%	40.7% (61)
ID House 2024	70 / 70	92.9%	28.6% (20)

- **Defensible claim.** Foreclosure is **not a Washington peculiarity** — in every state examined, **88–94% of lower-chamber seats were not close**, blue and red alike, and **more than a quarter offered no D-vs-R option**.
- **New York is one seat short, and it is Assembly District 23.** The Assembly has 150 districts; 149 carry a race in the loaded returns and **AD-23 carries none**. Its classification is therefore unknown, and the effect is bounded: if AD-23 was close the chamber reads **88.0%** not close, if it was not close, **88.7%**. The true figure lies in that range whichever way it resolves, so the finding does not turn on it — but "complete" would be the wrong word and is not used.
- **Texas is 64% loaded in the canvass returns**, and its figures depend on a backfill of the 54 uncontested seats that source omits. That backfill is now **verified seat by seat against the Secretary of State's certified results**, which independently show exactly those 54 districts as single-candidate, and supply the observed winning party for each (Appendix F). Its not-close seats split **56 D / 85 R**.
- Most recent loaded general: WA/TX/ID 2024, NY 2022.

Why it matters

The lead paper showed the off-year electorate is half-sized and older than the presidential one. This paper shows that even in the high-turnout even-year general, most legislative and congressional seats are not close, and a third of the ballot offers no choice between the parties.

Where a general election is not close, attention naturally turns to the August top-two primary as the round where the outcome is effectively determined. **The primary is much the smaller round**. Matching every seat to its own August primary on the corrected universe, the median primary race drew this share of the votes cast in the same seat's general:

2016	2018	2020	2022	2024
42.1%	55.9%	61.6%	61.2%	51.2%

Read this as a ratio of **votes cast in a contest**, not of distinct voters: roll-off and undervoting mean a race's vote total is not a headcount of participants. So in 2024 the median legislative or congressional primary recorded about half as many votes as the November contest for the same seat.

That the primary is smaller does not establish that it is where the decision was made. Observed November margins can show a race was not close; they cannot show *when* the binding choice occurred, or that a primary presented a meaningful alternative. Establishing that would require tracing each seat through its primary — whether it was contested, whether the eventual winner faced a credible same-party rival, and whether the general's finalists were themselves closely matched. That is the obvious sequel and is not attempted here.

What the evidence does support is narrower and still substantial: **a large share of Washington's legislative representation is settled in November by margins wide enough that the result was not in doubt, and for a third of seats without the voter ever being offered a choice between the two major parties**. Whether alternative primary or general-election structures — top-four, ranked choice — would increase candidate competition or cross-party choice is a question these findings motivate, not one they answer.

What this paper does not claim, and limits

- **It does not establish that seats were "decided before November."** That inference appeared in an earlier version and has been withdrawn. Observed general-election margins cannot date the binding decision.
- **"Not close" is not "illegitimate."** A forty-point margin can mean the voters there genuinely agree. The finding is strongest for the 23 single-candidate seats and the 15 same-party generals, and weakest as a democratic-deficit reading for lopsided D-vs-R contests. Appendix A takes this at full strength.
- **The partisan analysis is descriptive.** Safe-seat party totals and the seat/vote comparison in Appendix E describe patterns; they do not establish causation, intent, or gerrymandering. An earlier version claimed to make "no partisan-consequence claim" while analysing exactly that — the contradiction is resolved by scoping the claim rather than denying the analysis.
- **The Texas backfill is verified and its party split is now observed.** Earlier versions imputed holding party from presidential lean, which proved wrong in 5 of 54 seats. Party now comes from certified returns, and the split is 56 D / 85 R rather than the previously reported 51 D / 90 R. Appendix F documents the correction.
- **New York is a cycle behind** (2022) and missing Assembly District 23, which bounds its figure to 88.0–88.7%.
- **Margins are between candidates, not parties,** in Dimension 1. Third-party votes count toward the margin when a minor-party candidate is one of the top two.
- **Primary participation is measured in race votes, not voters** — see Appendix C.

Appendices

Appendix A — The objections, in full

- 1. Not-close seats still represent their voters.** A Solid-D Seattle seat and a Solid-R rural seat each *represent* the electorate that produced them; a wide margin can be agreement rather than foreclosure. This is the strongest objection and it is substantially correct for lopsided D-vs-R contests. It has far less force against the 23 seats that offered one name: no degree of voter agreement explains the absence of an alternative to agree or disagree with. The two-dimension design exists so that these cases are counted separately instead of averaged together.
- 2. The ten-point threshold is a knob.** True, and Appendix E tests the whole plausible range: the not-close share moves between 79% and 98% across cuts from 15 points to 5, and never approaches "competitive" at any setting. Dimension 2 is threshold-free entirely.
- 3. Same-party generals are a Washington artifact of top-two.** In states with party primaries the analogue is a seat with no major-party filer, and the four-state table folds both into one comparable bucket. But the deeper version of this objection — that a same-party general may be a real contest — is correct, was mishandled in the earlier version, and is now measured directly. One of Washington's fifteen same-party generals in 2024 was decided by six points.
- 4. The safe-seat split proves a gerrymander.** It does not, and the paper declines the claim. Washington's not-close seats split 68 D to 43 R against a 59.5% Democratic presidential vote — close to proportionate. Chen & Rodden (2013) is the standing demonstration that residential geography produces seat/vote bias with nobody drawing it, and single-member districts have no proportionality expectation to begin with. Appendix E reports the comparison descriptively and draws no inference about intent.
- 5. The Texas number rests on rows you added.** It did, and the objection prompted a proper check. The backfilled 54 have since been verified one by one against the Secretary of State's certified results, which independently identify exactly those districts as single-candidate and supply each winner's party. The headline was unchanged by the check (94.0% either way); the party split was not, and has been corrected. Appendix F sets out both. Excluding Texas entirely would still not change the paper's conclusion; it would remove the most extreme case.
- 6. Your earlier numbers were wrong.** Also correct. Appendix G documents what changed and why, rather than quietly restating.

Appendix B — Data access and provenance

- **What the figures are computed from.** Certified statewide general-election summary returns, one row per candidate per race, carrying race name, candidate, party preference and vote total. These are **published aggregate election results** — this paper touches no voter file and no personal data, and carries no privacy surface.

- **Washington.** Secretary of State certified statewide summaries, files `20161108_AllState.csv`, `20181106_AllState.csv`, `20201103_AllState.csv`, `20221108_AllState.csv`, `20241105_AllState.csv`. These are the authoritative source for the seat universe. The corresponding `_AllStatePrecincts.csv` files are **not** used for the universe, because King County is largely absent from them in 2016 and 2018 — the defect Appendix G describes.
- **New York.** State Board of Elections returns as ingested into the project warehouse. *Provenance note: the repository's loader path for New York results involves an intermediary; the exact ingested artifact and its transformation commit should be cited alongside the originating authority before publication.*
- **Idaho.** Secretary of State certified returns.
- **Texas.** Two sources, because one is insufficient. The Legislative Council's canvass-grade VTD returns supply precinct-level results but **omit uncontested races at every stage**, carrying 96 of 150 House districts. The **Texas Secretary of State's election-night results service** (`results.texas-election.com`, read 2026-07-27) publishes all 150 including uncontested ones with candidate, party and votes; it is the seat universe and the source of holding party, captured to `data/raw/tx/2024_tx_house_candidates.csv`. The TLC r206 report (`planh2316_r206_election24g.xls`) is retained only for district presidential lean in Appendix E.
- **Outstanding for publication.** Full dataset citations — release date, access date, archived location, checksum, and loader commit — are not yet assembled for every source and should be before circulation.

Appendix C — Methods

- **Universe.** Built from certified statewide summary returns and asserted against the statutory chamber size (98 WA House positions, 10 U.S. House, Senate staggered). `scripts/diag_seat_competition.py` exits non-zero on any mismatch. Write-ins are excluded; candidates with zero votes are excluded.
- **Party.** Taken from the certified "Prefers ___ Party" string. Only Democratic/Democrat and Republican/GOP count as major; Independent-, Culture- and MAGA-prefixed strings are counted as other, with a sensitivity test reported in the body. Because top-two has no nominees, this is a statement about stated preference, not nomination.
- **Dimension 1, candidate competition.** Margin between the top two candidates by votes, regardless of party: $|first - second| / (first + second)$. Bands: Tossup <5, Lean 5–10, Likely 10–20, Solid 20+. "Not close" = single candidate or margin ≥ 10 .
- **Dimension 2, partisan availability.** Classified from the set of parties actually on the ballot: D-v-R, D-v-D, R-v-R, D-v-other, R-v-other, other-only, single candidate.
- **Winner party** is the party of the leading candidate. An earlier version inferred it by comparing aggregate D and R vote totals, which mislabels a race where both are zero; Appendix G records the fix.
- **Primary participation.** Each general seat is matched to its same-office, same-district August primary, and the reported figure is the **median ratio of primary race votes to general race votes** — a comparison of votes cast in a contest, *not* of distinct voters. Roll-off and undervoting affect race totals, so the two are not interchangeable. Recomputed on the corrected universe (all five cycles, every seat matched): 42.1 / 55.9 / 61.6 / 61.2 / 51.2% for 2016–2024. The 2024 and 2022 figures are within a point of the previously published ~51% and ~62%, so the correction to the seat universe did not move this measure.
- **Reproduction.** `scripts/diag_seat_competition.py` builds the classification and writes `reports/seat_competition.csv` (one row per seat, both dimensions). Supporting scripts: `diag_safe_seat_states.py` (four-state), `diag_tx_safe_seat_backfill.py` (Appendix F), `diag_safe_seat_robustness.py` (Appendix E), `diag_safe_seat_party_ratio.py` and `diag_efficiency_gap.py` (Appendix E's exploratory cuts).

Appendix D — Related work

- **The primary as the real election under one-party dominance.** V. O. Key Jr., with the assistance of Alexander Heard, *Southern Politics in State and Nation* (New York: Alfred A. Knopf, 1949). Hirano & Snyder, *Primary Elections in the United States* (Cambridge University Press, 2019), doi:10.1017/9781139946537.
- **The decline of competition in general elections.** Abramowitz, Alexander & Gunning, "Incumbency, Redistricting, and the Decline of Competition in U.S. House Elections," *Journal of Politics* 68(1) (2006): 75–88, doi:10.1111/j.1468-2508.2006.00371.x.
- **Uncontested seats as their own phenomenon.** Squire, "Uncontested Seats in State Legislative Elections," *Legislative Studies Quarterly* 25(1) (2000): 131–146. Burden & Snyder, "Explaining Uncontested Seats in Congress and State

Legislatures," *American Politics Research* 49(3) (2021): 247–258, doi:10.1177/1532673X20960565 — on why parties decline to field candidates, the mechanism behind Appendix E's contest gap.

- **Political geography versus intentional gerrymandering.** Chen & Rodden, "Unintentional Gerrymandering: Political Geography and Electoral Bias in Legislatures," *Quarterly Journal of Political Science* 8(3) (2013): 239–269 — residential concentration produces seat/vote bias without deliberate line-drawing. Stephanopoulos & McGhee, "Partisan Gerrymandering and the Efficiency Gap," *University of Chicago Law Review* 82 (2015): 831–900 — the source of the efficiency-gap measure and of the benchmark Appendix E reports against.
- **Off-cycle timing and who is left deciding.** Anzia, *Timing and Turnout: How Off-Cycle Elections Favor Organized Groups* (University of Chicago Press, 2014).
- **Top-two and primary reform.** McGhee & Shor, "Has the Top Two Primary Elected More Moderates?" *Perspectives on Politics* 15(4) (2017): 1053–1066, doi:10.1017/S1537592717002158 — addresses candidate *moderation* under top-two, with mixed and jurisdiction-dependent findings; it is cited here for institutional context and does not speak directly to whether top-two restores general-election competition.
- **Safe-seat prevalence, advocacy literature.** FairVote's *Monopoly Politics* series reports projected House competitiveness. *A specific edition, year, report title and archived location must be supplied before publication; the series is cited here as background only.*

Appendix E — Robustness, and exploratory cuts

Threshold sensitivity. The not-close share across margin cutoffs. The Washington rows come from `scripts/diag_seat_competition.py` on the corrected universe, using the same code path as the headline, so the ≥ 10 column reproduces Dimension 1 exactly; the other chambers come from `scripts/diag_safe_seat_robustness.py`.

scope	$\geq 5\text{pt}$	$\geq 8\text{pt}$	$\geq 10\text{pt}$	$\geq 12\text{pt}$	$\geq 15\text{pt}$	seats
WA all seats	92.5%	88.0%	83.5%	77.4%	73.7%	133
WA House	95.9%	91.8%	87.8%	80.6%	76.5%	98
NY Assembly	94.6%	92.6%	88.6%	85.2%	82.6%	149
TX House	98.0%	96.0%	94.0%	91.3%	86.0%	150
ID House	95.7%	92.9%	92.9%	91.4%	90.0%	70

Even at a stringent 15-point cut, **74–90%** of seats are not close; at a loose 5-point cut, 93–98%. There is no threshold at which these chambers look competitive.

The contest gap. Comparing each chamber's actual not-close share with the share of its districts that are ≥ 10 -point safe by 2024 presidential lean. The Washington figure uses the corrected House number:

	actual	presidential-lean safe	gap
WA House	87.8%	79.6%	+ 8.2 pp
TX House	94.0%	84.0%	+ 10.0 pp
ID House	92.9%	94.3%	– 1.4 pp

In the two states with genuine partisan diversity, actual contestation runs about ten points worse than the map predicts — parties decline to field candidates where the presidential numbers say a seat is winnable — while in deep-one-party Idaho the gap vanishes. The pathology is strongest where competition is possible. (New York cannot be tested: its loaded presidential data predates the 2022 Assembly lines.)

Exploratory: seat/vote ratio and partisan symmetry. *This section is descriptive and should be read as a prompt for further work rather than a finding.* Measured against each state's 2024 presidential two-party vote, not-close seats over-represent the locally dominant party, and the gap widens with the state's lopsidedness: Washington +2.6 points, Texas +6.9, Idaho +18.9. That pattern is **consistent with** packing, and equally consistent with residential geography, district-boundary effects, turnout differences, and the definition of "safe" used here; single-member districts carry no proportionality expectation, and this comparison examines only safe seats rather than the whole distribution. It cannot distinguish those mechanisms or establish a counterfactual seat distribution. Under the efficiency-gap specifications reported by `scripts/diag_efficiency_gap.py`,

no state exceeds the ~8-point level Stephanopoulos & McGhee (2015) discuss; the script computes more than one formulation and the values differ, the metric is sensitive to turnout distribution, and none of this determines whether a map is an outlier against neutral ensembles or was drawn with intent. Establishing that requires map-simulation work this paper does not attempt.

Exploratory: comparison with the project's forecast. This project's forecast bands 53 of 59 Washington districts (90%) as ≥ 10 -point safe for 2026, against 83.5% of seats measured as not-close on 2024 results. These are **different units, different years, and different denominators** — districts versus seats — so the similarity is a loose aggregate consistency check, **not a validation**. A real validation would predict historical elections without using their outcomes and report classification accuracy, calibration, and false-safe rates on the same unit.

Appendix F — The Texas backfill

Texas is the one state where this paper adds rows rather than only counting them.

The problem. The Texas Legislative Council's canvass-grade VTD returns omit uncontested races: when a seat is unopposed no precinct tally is published. The warehouse therefore carried **96 of 150** TX House districts, and the missing 54 were missing *because* they were uncontested — exactly the category this paper counts. Left alone, the omission biases Texas toward looking more competitive than it is.

The construction. The 54 absent districts are backfilled as *no major-party choice*, with holding party assigned from each district's 2024 presidential lean using the on-disk TLC r206 report (`planh2316_r206_election24g.xls`). Script: `scripts/diag_tx_safe_seat_backfill.py` . The results database was not mutated.

Verified against a certified source. The backfill was checked seat by seat against the Texas Secretary of State's election-night results service, which publishes every race including uncontested ones with candidate name, party and votes (`scripts/build_tx_house_candidates.py` → `data/raw/tx/2024_tx_house_candidates.csv` ; audit in `scripts/diag_tx_backfill_verification.py` → `reports/tx_backfill_verification.csv`).

The match is exact. The certified source shows **54 single-candidate districts**, and they are precisely the 54 the TLC returns omit — no district was backfilled that was actually contested, and no uncontested district was missed. The backfill is confirmed in full, not merely for a named subset. As an external check on the extraction, the certified data also puts the 2024 chamber at 62 D / 88 R, matching the seated Texas House.

Why the TLC data could never have settled this. It omits uncontested races at *every* stage, not just the general: all 14 districts on the press-reported unopposed list appear in **neither** 2024 party primary, because those candidates were unopposed there too. Absence is a property of the whole dataset, so no amount of work inside it could distinguish "uncontested" from "missing".

Holding party is now observed, and the old imputation was wrong. Party for the 54 comes from the certified returns rather than presidential lean. Retrospectively, the retired imputation was **wrong in 5 of 54** — HD 35, 36, 40, 42 and 144, every one a district Trump carried while a Democrat held the seat, mostly Rio Grande Valley. The observed split of the backfilled seats is **36 D / 18 R**, against 31 D / 23 R imputed. Correcting it moves the chamber's not-close split from the previously reported 51 D / 90 R to **56 D / 85 R**.

The headline was unaffected throughout. Not-close remains **141 of 150 = 94.0%** on certified data, identical to the backfilled figure, because that count needs only the seats to have been uncontested — which is exactly what the certified source confirms. Without the backfill, on the 96 contested-skewed districts, Texas would read 90.6% and just 7.3% without a D-vs-R option, visibly biased toward competitiveness.

Appendix G — What changed in this revision, and why

An adversarial review of the prior version identified three defects. All were confirmed against the code and data, and all are corrected here.

1. The seat universe was incomplete. The prior analysis derived races from the precinct-results table. King County is essentially absent from Washington's statewide *precinct* files for 2016 and 2018 — about 190 of 330,845 rows in 2016 — so every King legislative race silently vanished: 24 House seats per year, districts 5, 11, 33, 34, 36, 37, 41, 43, 45, 46, 47 and 48. The warehouse held 74 of 98 House seats in both years. A separate format variant (2020 LD15 spelled "Representative, Position N" rather than "State Representative Pos. N") dropped two more. The certified summary files carry every race and were already on disk, so the fix required no new data — only building the universe from a certified race list and asserting it against the statutory chamber size.

2. "Same-party" was misclassified. The rule was `same_party if (d == 0 or r == 0)` , which captures *any* race lacking a

D-vs-R pairing — including D-vs-independent and R-vs-Libertarian. Of the 23 races the prior version labelled same-party in 2024, **seven were not same-party at all**. Relatedly, winner party was inferred by comparing aggregate D and R totals, so a race with neither would have been scored Democratic; no such race occurred in 2024, but the rule was wrong and is now taken from the leading candidate.

3. Two questions were collapsed into one. Every same-party general was scored non-competitive regardless of margin. That is a statement about partisan availability presented as a statement about competitiveness.

Effect on the headline figures:

year	prior "non-competitive"	corrected "not close"	change
2016	90.7%	88.1%	-2.6
2018	75.0%	78.9%	+3.9
2020	84.1%	83.6%	-0.5
2022	87.1%	86.5%	-0.6
2024	85.0%	83.5%	-1.5

The most consequential change is 2018. The prior version reported a dramatic dip to 75% in the blue-wave year; on the complete universe the dip is to **78.9%** — still the least foreclosed cycle in the series, but a good part of the apparent drop was 24 missing King County seats, which are disproportionately safe and Democratic. The headline moves from "roughly 85%" to **"roughly 84%"**, and the decade range tightens from 75–91% to 79–88%.

The 2024 no-major-choice count moves from 46 to **47**, and is now correctly described: 23 single-candidate, 15 same-party, 9 major-versus-minor.

Also withdrawn: the claim that seats were "decided before November," which observed November margins cannot establish; and the assertion that the safe-seat ratio is a "packing signature," now reported as a descriptive comparison consistent with several mechanisms.

End note — data, reproduction, and series

```
# The rebuilt classification - universe assertion + both dimensions + sensitivity:
python scripts/diag_seat_competition.py          # writes reports/seat_competition.csv

# Four-state lower-chamber count and the Texas completion:
python scripts/diag_safe_seat_states.py
python scripts/diag_tx_safe_seat_backfill.py      # Appendix F backfill
python scripts/build_tx_house_candidates.py       # certified TX candidate list (all 150)
python scripts/diag_tx_backfill_verification.py   # Appendix F seat-by-seat verification
                                                    # -> reports/tx_backfill_verification.csv

# Robustness and the exploratory cuts:
python scripts/diag_safe_seat_robustness.py       # Appendix E thresholds + contest gap
python scripts/diag_safe_seat_party_ratio.py      # seat/vote ratio
python scripts/diag_efficiency_gap.py             # partisan-symmetry diagnostic
```

All inputs are published election returns. See [data-sources-and-reproducibility.md](#) for the source ledger and [publication-checklist.md](#) for the verification ledger of expected values.

Companion to the electoral-health series lead, [who-decides-washington.md](#), with [who-decides-new-york.md](#) and [who-decides-idaho.md](#) (party-resolved electorates), [donor-class-and-the-electorate.md](#) (who funds them), [cross-state-fec-money.md](#) (the four-state money layer), and [does-money-move-votes.md](#) (whether that money moves margins).